TOPIC 1

Studying Help

What makes tutoring work

TOPIC 1 · STUDYING HELP

High-Quality Tutoring Works

50th → ~63rd

percentile: where a typical tutored student ends up

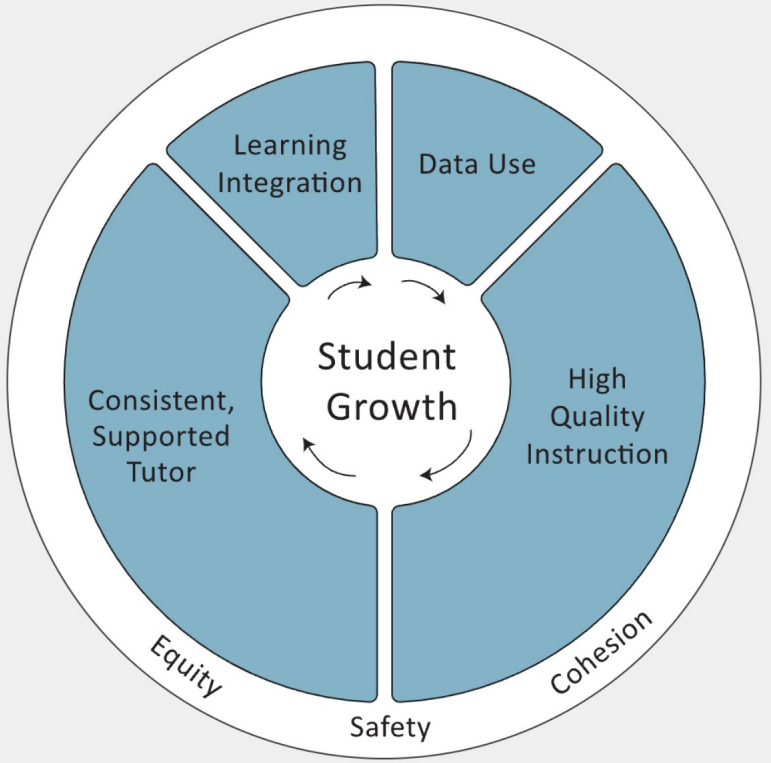
- Meets individual needs
- Builds relationships
- Supports well-being
- Increases attendance
- Accelerates learning by 3–15 months

Stanford SCALE / National Student Support Accelerator · Loeb & Robinson 2026 synthesis of meta-analyses

TOPIC 1 · STUDYING HELP

What the Best Tutoring Programs Share

1	Frequent sessions	AI: strong
2	Aligned with the course	AI: weak
3	Uses evidence to adjust	AI: partial
4	The same tutor over time	AI: partial
5	Trained, supported tutors	AI: weak



The Elements of High-Impact Tutoring

Stanford SCALE, “AI Tutoring Is Not a Monolith” and “Homework Helper or AI Tutor?” (Aug 2026)

DISCUSSION

Can the friend close these gaps?

Aligned with the course | Uses evidence to adjust | The same tutor over time | Trained, supported tutors

1

What would it take for AI to do this well?

2

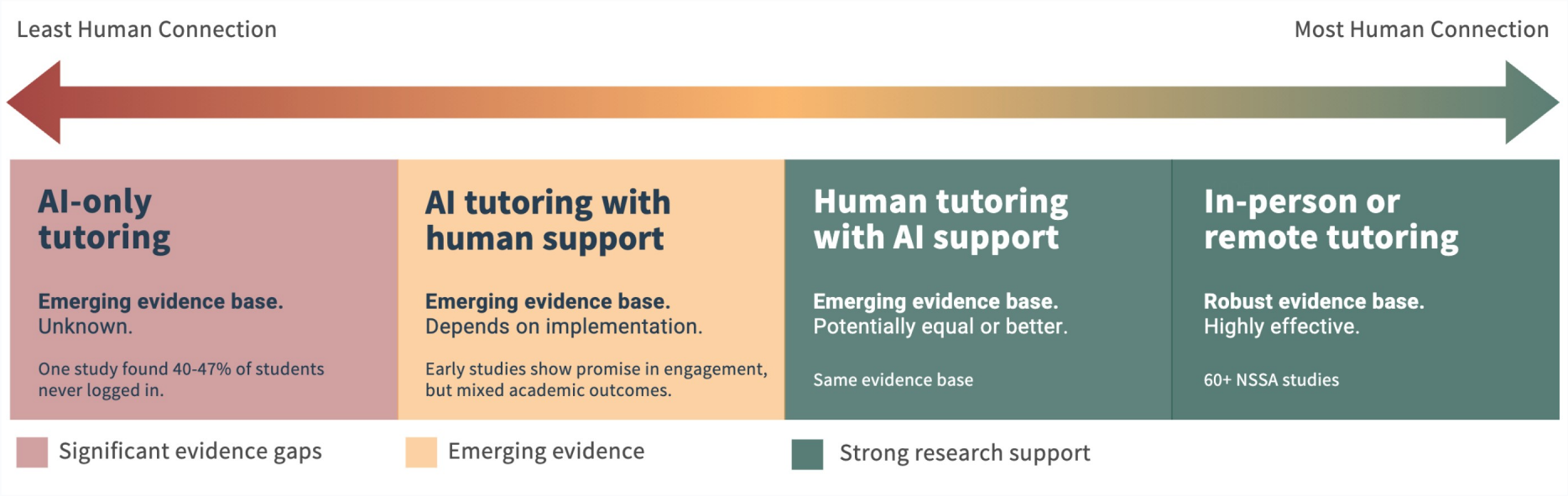
Which can it never do well, however it's set up? Why?

3

What requires a human connection?

TOPIC 1 · STUDYING HELP

A Spectrum, From All AI to All Human



The human end works, but it's hard to scale

The AI end scales, but doesn't always work

Stanford SCALE / National Student Support Accelerator, "AI Tutoring Is Not a Monolith" (Aug 2026)

TOPIC 1 · THE AI-ONLY END

AI Alone: Better Homework, Worse Exams

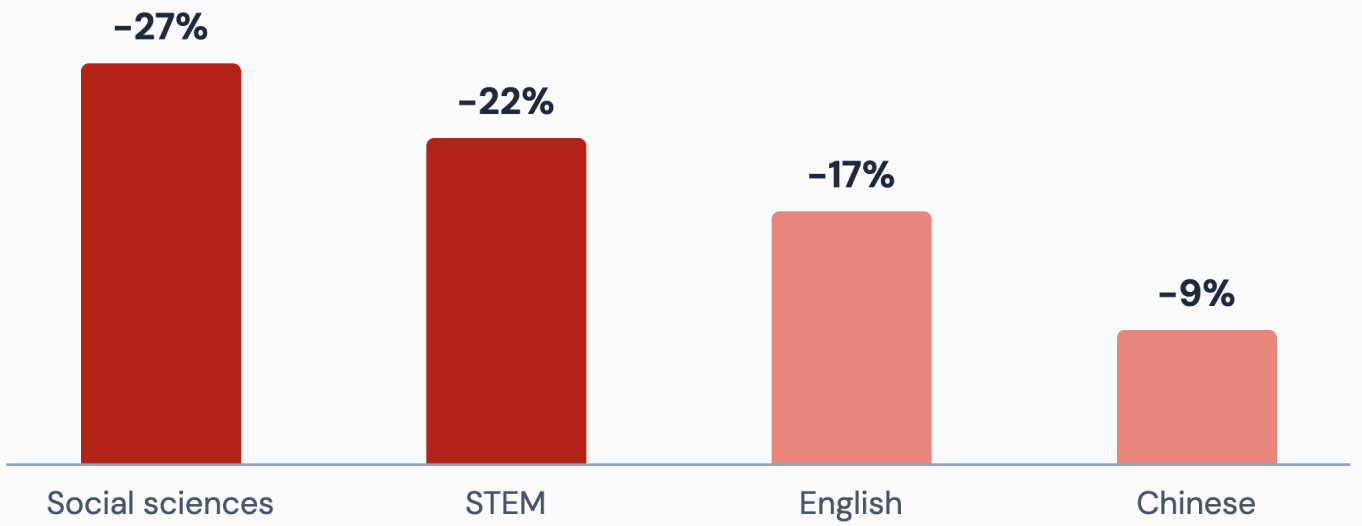
+18%
homework scores

−20%
monthly exam scores

Homework time fell from 64 to 45 minutes.

The losses grew over two years: high school entrance exams **−24%**, college entrance exams **−18%**.

Drop in exam scores after starting AI, by subject



Strömberg, Lei & Wu, CEPR Discussion Paper 21577 (VoxEU, Sep 2026) · 26,811 students, grades 7–12, central China, 30 months

TOPIC 1 · IMPLEMENTATION

The Design Details Decide the Result

What the AI gives

Helped: one step or hint at a time (Harvard)

Hurt: full answers (Bastani: exam −17%)

Who tries first

Helped: student attempts before help (Harvard)

Hurt: AI first, weaker engagement (Kosmyna)

What it knows

Helped: expert solutions and a designed sequence (Harvard)

No effect: course materials alone (Thoeni & Fryer)

How it's offered

Helped: scheduled, supervised sessions (Nigeria, Ghana)

Hurt: just made available (Maryland: −0.37 SD)

Who it talks to

Helped: coaching the human tutor (Tutor CoPilot)

Weak: students alone (40–47% never logged in)

Same underlying models, very different outcomes.